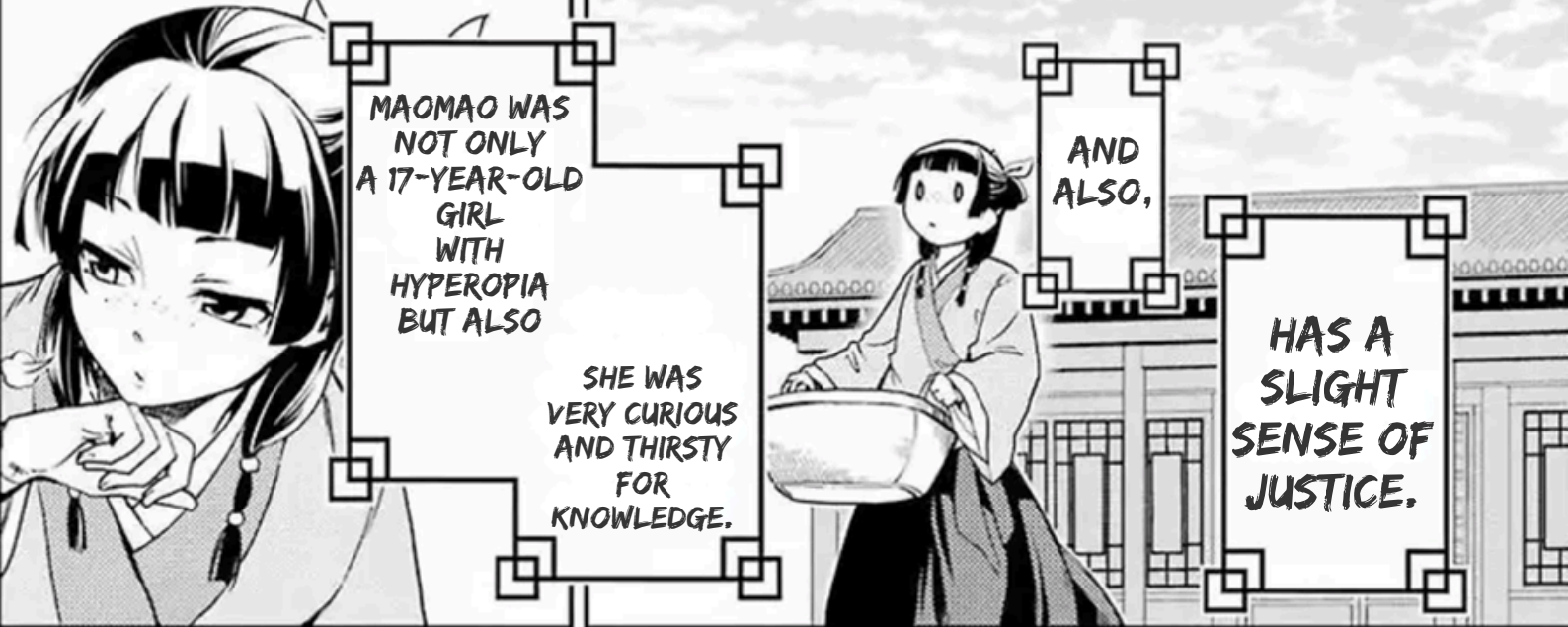




MAOMAO WAS
NOT ONLY
A 17-YEAR-OLD
GIRL
WITH
HYPEROPIA
BUT ALSO

SHE WAS
VERY CURIOUS
AND THIRSTY
FOR
KNOWLEDGE.

AND
ALSO,

HAS A
SLIGHT
SENSE OF
JUSTICE.



IN THE DAYS
THAT
FOLLOWED,
SHE WOULD
LEARN
THAT LIFE
DOESN'T
ALWAYS GO
THE WAY YOU
PLANNED IT.



SERVANT
Shaolan

I'M SO
SCARED,
EVERYONE
SAYS IT'S A
CURSE!

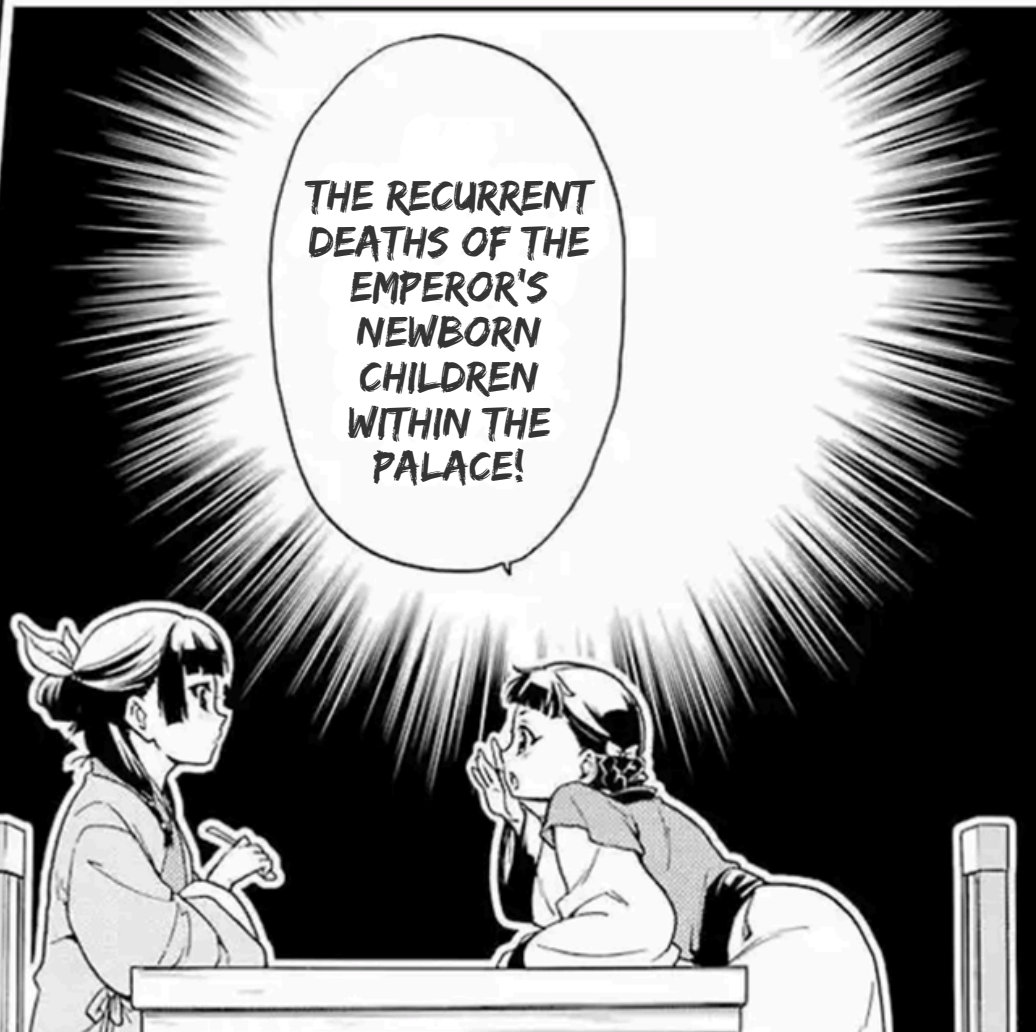
A RUMOR
WAS
CIRCULA-
TING
AROUND
THE
IMPERIAL
COURT.



...
WHAT
ARE YOU
TALKING
ABOUT?



DON'T
YOU
KNOW?!



THE RECURRENT
DEATHS OF THE
EMPEROR'S
NEWBORN
CHILDREN
WITHIN THE
PALACE!



IT SEEMS
THAT
3 CHILDREN
OF THE
EMPEROR

DIED
JUST AFTER
THEY WERE
BORN!

DON'T YOU
THINK
IT'S
SUSPICIOUS?



THE
CHILDREN
BORN
IN THE
PALACE,

WHO
WOULD
BECOME
MEMBERS
OF THE
ROYAL
COURT

ONE
BEFORE
THE
EMPEROR
WAS CO-
RONATED...

TWO
AFTER
THAT...

IN TOTAL
THREE
OF THE
EMPEROR'S
CHILDREN
HAVE
ALREADY DIED
WHILE STILL
INFANTS.

CURRENTLY,

HEIR
3 MONTHS
OLD
MALE
AGE



AND THE
PRINCESS
WHO IS 6
MONTHS
OLD

ARE THE
ONLY
SURVIVORS.

THEIR
MOTHERS
ARE

HER
MAJESTY
RIFA, WHO
GAVE BIRTH
TO THE
MALE HEIR.

HOWE-
VER,

I SUPPOSE
THAT BECAUSE
THE
EMPEROR
DOES NOT
HAVE A
PRINCIPAL
EMPRESS,

SHE WHO
GAVE BIRTH TO
THE
MALE HEIR
IS THE ONE WHO
HAS
THE HIGHEST RANK

IT SEEMS
THAT THE
EMPEROR
FAVORS
MORE

WHO GAVE
BIRTH
TO THE
PRINCESS,
HER
MAJESTY
GYOKUYOU.





AND I JUST HEARD THAT THE DOCTOR IS HEADING

TO SEE THE BABY OF HIS MAJESTY GYOKUYOU!

I KNEW IT! IT'S A CURSED!

THERE IS NO SUCH THING AS CURSES.



IF IT WERE A DISPUTE OVER THE SUCCESSION, THERE WOULD BE NO REASON TO ATTACK THE PRINCESS.

SO I GUESS THE PROBABILITY OF POISONING IS LOW.

IF WE ASSUME THAT IT IS A DISEASE,

THEN IT COULD BE HEREDITARY



THE BABIES BEFORE THEM...

DO YOU KNOW HOW THEY DIED?

UHM ...

I'M NOT SURE OF THE DETAILS, BUT...



THEY SAY THAT SUDDENLY THEY BEGAN TO WEAKEN.

IT SEEMS THAT THIS TIME IT COULD BE THE SAME.

THEY EVEN SAY THAT THE CONDITION OF HIS MAJESTY RIFA IS NOT GOOD EITHER.

IS RIFA SICK?

THAT'S
RIGHT.

I ALSO
LISTEN

HE IS
SUFFERING
FROM
STOMACH
PAIN,
HEADACHES,
AND
NAUSEA.



STOMACH PAIN,
HEADACHE, AND
NAUSEA, UH...



A SIMPLE
RUMOR
COULD BE
MORE
SERIOUS
THAN I
THOUGHT.



I CANNOT
DO
ANYTHING
BUT
SPECULATE,

BUT...

I
GUESS I
COULD
TAKE A
LOOK.





JUST
BECAUSE
YOUR
DESCENDANT
IS A WOMAN!

EMPRESS MINOR
RIFA

EMPRESS MINOR
GYOKUYOU





THE
DEATH
OF THE
BABIES...

HEADACHES,
STOMACHACHES,
AND
NAUSEA.



AND MOST
IMPORTANTLY

HER
MAJESTY
RIFA
LOOKS LIKE
SHE
HAS LOST
SOME
WEIGHT.



AS I
SUSPECTED



**THIS IS NOT
A CURSE**



THAT
DAY,

AFTER
REALIZING
WHAT
WAS
HAPPENING,

I LEFT
NOTES FOR
THEIR
MAJESTIES.



IT WAS
SIMPLE.

THE FACE
POWDER
USED IN THE
PALACE
CONTAINS
POISON, SO
ALL THEY HAD
TO DO
WAS NOT USE IT.



IGNORANCE
IS A
SIN,
ISN'T IT?

IF ONLY
I HAD
PAID
MORE
ATTENTION
TO

WHAT I WAS
PUTTING IN
THE BABY'S
REACH...



WHO SENT
THE
MESSAGE?